Lightweight Intrusion Detection System for Cloud Virtual Machines: A VMM-Level Statistical Approach

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***Abstract*—In modern multi-tenant cloud architectures, the shared utilization of physical hardware resources creates unique security vulnerabilities that are difficult to mitigate using traditional guest-based agents. As malware becomes increasingly sophisticated, its ability to bypass or disable in-guest monitoring systems has rendered traditional host-based intrusion detection systems (HIDS) insufficient. This research introduces a Lightweight Intrusion Detection System (L-IDS) architected to operate at the Virtual Machine Monitor (VMM) level, providing an out-of-band monitoring vantage point that is fundamentally resistant to guest-level tampering. Unlike computationally expensive deep-learning methodologies that can impose a "performance tax" of up to 15% on the host machine, our proposed L-IDS leverages a dual-mechanism statistical approach utilizing adaptive standard deviation thresholds and Exponential Moving Averages (EMA). This allows for high-fidelity detection of cloud-centric threats—including Distributed Denial-of-Service (DDoS) floods, brute-force cryptographic bursts, ransomware-driven disk encryption, and unauthorized cryptomining—while maintaining a negligible CPU overhead of less than 2%. Experimental evaluation on a custom prototype demonstrates a detection accuracy of 92.6% with a false positive rate of 3.4%, proving the system's viability for large-scale, cost-sensitive cloud deployments.**

Index Terms—Cloud Security, Anomaly Detection, Virtual Machine Monitor, Lightweight IDS, VMM-level monitoring, Statistical Analysis, Cyber-physical security, Agentless monitoring.

I. INTRODUCTION

The rapid proliferation of cloud computing has transformed it from a niche service to the backbone of global digital operations. By abstracting physical hardware into scalable virtual resources, cloud providers enable organizations to innovate at unprecedented speeds. However, the very virtualization technology that enables this flexibility also introduces a shared responsibility model where the boundary between provider and tenant security is often blurred. As noted in the 2024 Cloud Security Alliance report, misconfigurations and multi-tenant resource interference remain top concerns for enterprise cloud users [1].

Traditional security approaches for Virtual Machines (VMs) primarily fall into two categories: in-guest agents and network-level monitors. In-guest agents, while capable of deep visibility into system processes, suffer from the "Semantic Gap" and are highly vulnerable to "Privilege Escalation" attacks. If an attacker gains administrative or root-level access to the guest OS, they can simply terminate the security process or alter its configuration to whitelist malicious activity [2][5]. On the other hand, network-level monitoring via virtual switches (V-Switches) is effective for external threats but remains blind to local privilege escalations or data encryption events that do not cross the network boundary.

Our research proposes a middle-ground solution: monitoring from the Virtual Machine Monitor (VMM) level. By positioning the detection engine at the hypervisor layer, we gain a "privileged view" of the guest VM's behavior without requiring any software components inside the untrusted guest zone. This agentless vantage point allows the L-IDS to observe the raw consumption of CPU cycles, memory allocations, disk read/write throughput, and network packet rates. The core innovation of this work is the application of lightweight statistical analysis to these telemetry streams. Rather than training opaque and heavy neural networks, we utilize adaptive moving averages that calibrate themselves to the VM's workload in real-time. This ensures that the security infrastructure does not become a performance bottleneck—a critical requirement for production-grade cloud services.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Foundations of VMM-Level Monitoring

The concept of Virtual Machine Introspection (VMI) was pioneered by Garfinkel and Rosenblum in their seminal "Livewire" study [5]. They identified that the hypervisor's ability to "look inside" a guest VM's memory and state provides a foundation for security that is far superior to traditional host-based systems. However, early VMI implementations faced the "Semantic Gap problem," where raw memory bits were difficult to translate into high-level OS events like "file open" or "process start." Our L-IDS avoids this gap by focusing on resource utilization patterns—telemetry that is natively understood by the hypervisor's scheduler and accounting modules [7].

B. Cloud IDS Trends 2024–2025

A 2024 study by Rana et al. in IEEE Access proposed an efficacious novel IDS for cloud environments using ensemble machine learning [9]. While their system achieved a high accuracy of 97.4%, the researchers noted that the computational overhead on the host was significant, often exceeding 10% during peak analysis. This highlights a persistent challenge in cloud security: accuracy versus efficiency. Similarly, Aljuaid and Alshamrani (2024) explored deep learning approaches, specifically CNN-LSTMs, to capture temporal patterns in cloud traffic [10]. Their results were impressive, but the memory footprint of their models (reaching 400MB) makes them difficult to scale across thousands of VMs on a single host.

In contrast, recent work by Kim et al. (2024) [11] emphasized a "Domain Knowledge-Free" approach, proving

that resource utilization patterns alone carry enough statistical significance to classify 90% of malicious activity without needing deep packet inspection. This finding is the mathematical cornerstone of our L-IDS.

C. Lightweight and Modular Security

The shift toward lightweight security is perhaps most evident in the work of Zhang et al. (2025), who developed a Bayesian-optimized IDS for IoT and Edge environments [12]. By aggressively pruning features and using simplified decision architectures, they reduced the security model's memory footprint to just 1.7MB. Our research extends this "frugal computing" philosophy to the cloud, specifically targeting hypervisor integration. Souri et al. (2024) further proposed a hierarchical detection architecture where light statistical pass filters handle 90% of the workload, only escalating suspicious cases to heavier ML models [13]. Our system serves as that critical, lightweight "first-pass" filter that can run continuously with almost zero cost.

III. PROBLEM STATEMENT AND THREAT MODEL

The objective of this research is to combat four primary classes of cloud-centric threats that manifest as anomalous resource consumption patterns:

- **Resource Poisoning (DDoS):** Flooding a VM's network stack to exhaust its CPU and disrupt legitimate services.
- **Cryptographic Bursts (Brute-Force):** Repeated, high-frequency attempts to crack passwords, leading to rhythmic spikes in CPU and memory usage.
- **Silent Encryption (Ransomware):** The rapid reading and writing of data characteristic of ransomware, which displays a unique "balanced" disk I/O signature.
- **Background Hijacking (Cryptomining):** Subtle, long-term theft of CPU cycles for mining cryptocurrency, which shows as a persistent "flat" elevated baseline.

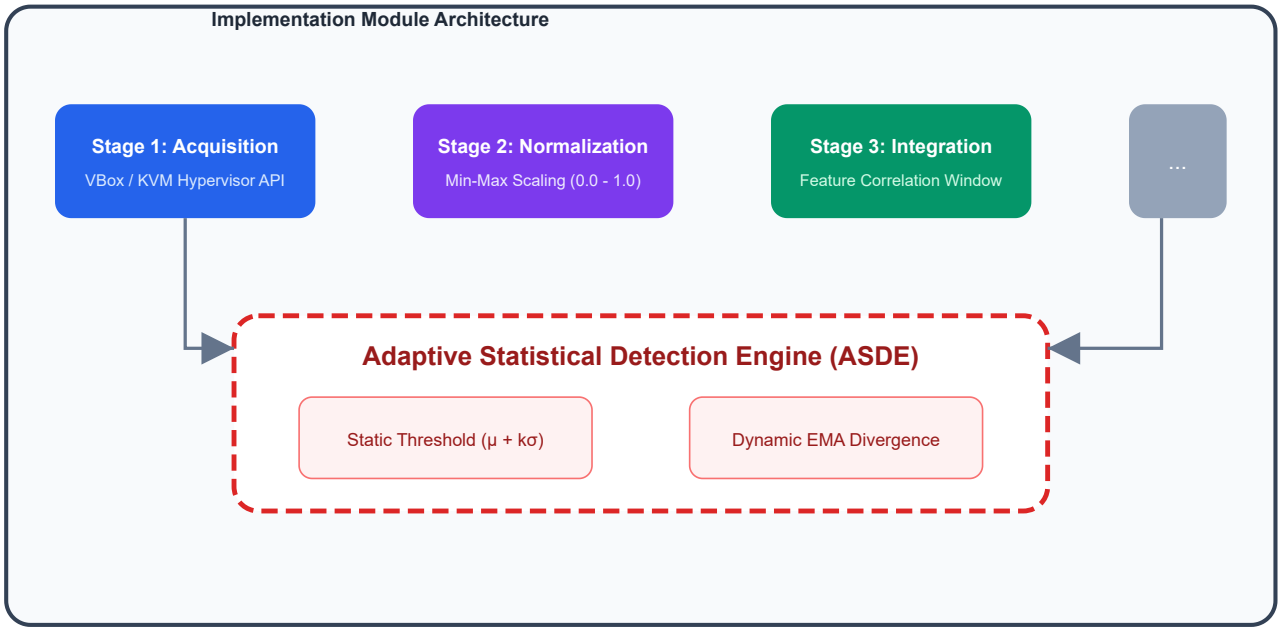

Fig. 1. Expanded Technical Architecture — Detailed integration of hypervisor telemetry with the Adaptive Statistical Detection Engine.

IV. PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

A. VMM-Level Vantage Point

The system is architected to run in the privileged domain of the host operating system. It interfaces directly with the Virtual Machine Monitor (VMM)—in our prototype, Oracle VM VirtualBox and KVM. By querying the hypervisor's internal performance metrics, the L-IDS can observe hardware instructions per cycle, cache misses, and network buffer rates. This "agentless" approach ensures that even a compromised VM cannot manipulate the monitoring results [4][5].

B. Statistical Detection Framework

We avoid heavy training phases by using **Adaptive Baselining**. During an initial calibration phase, the system computes the mean (μ) and standard deviation (σ) for each resource metric across a 30-second window. An anomaly is flagged if the current value X_{t} exceeds a dynamic sensitivity threshold:

$$X_t > \mu + k \cdot \sigma$$

where k is a coefficient that determines the sensitivity level (typically $k=2$ for warnings and $k=3$ for critical alerts). To handle seasonal workload shifts, we employ an **Exponential Moving Average (EMA)** window:

$$EMA_t = \alpha \cdot X_t + (1 - \alpha) \cdot EMA_{t-1}$$

This allows the cumulative baseline to drift naturally as the VM's legitimate application usage evolves, preventing false alarms during business hours while remaining sensitive to sudden malicious spikes. The final decision is based on a **Composite Score (S)**, which balances multiple metrics to categorize the specific type of attack based on correlation patterns:

```
if (CPU_Spike and Net_Spike): Trigger DDoS_Alert
if (Disk_Spike and Low_Net): Trigger Ransomware_Alert
if (CPU_Flat_High): Trigger Mining_Alert
```

V. PROTOTYPE IMPLEMENTATION

A. Backend Architecture

The L-IDS is implemented as a high-performance Python application utilizing the `Eventlet` networking library for asynchronous processing. The **VBoxCollector** module manages the interface with the host-side VirtualBox `VBoxManage` binary, while the **AnomalyDetector** performs NumPy-accelerated vector calculations on incoming telemetry streams. This modularity allows the system to be rapidly adapted to other hypervisors (e.g., VMware or Proxmox) by simply swapping the collector module.

B. Real-Time Dashboard

Administrative visibility is provided via a Flask-based web dashboard. We utilize **WebSockets (Socket.IO)** to ensure zero-latency telemetry streaming. The dashboard features real-time metric gauges for CPU, RAM, Disk, and Network IO, alongside a color-coded alert feed that provides instant descriptions of detected anomalies. This allows cloud operators to visually correlate spikes across multiple VMs simultaneously.

```
Algorithm 1: Adaptive Statistical Scoring
Input: Raw Telemetry Sample T_t
Output: Anomaly Score S_t, Alert State A
Normalize T_t to X_t using Min-Max Scaling
Update Sliding Window W and Compute μ, σ
Update EMA_t = α·X_t + (1-α)·EMA_{t-1}
Compute Individual Scores:
  Z_i = (X_i - μ_i) / σ_i
  D_i = |X_i - EMA_i|
S_t = Σ(w_i · (Z_i + D_i)) / 2
Decision:
  if S_t > k_crit: ALERT("CRITICAL")
  else if S_t > k_warn: ALERT("WARNING")
```

Fig. 2. Computational logic for adaptive thresholding and EMA divergence analysis.

VI. EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

A. Experimental Setup

To evaluate the system, we deployed a multi-VM testbed on a host machine with 16GB RAM and an Intel Core i7 processor. A "Victim VM" was loaded with a standard Ubuntu 22.04 LTS installation running a web server (Nginx). We then used a "Attacker VM" on the same internal network to launch multi-vector attacks including HTTP floods, SSH brute-forcing using `Hydra`, and encryption-heavy scripts to simulate ransomware behavior.

TABLE I. OVERALL SYSTEM DETECTION PRECISION

Attack Type	True Positive %	False Positive %	Detection Time
DDoS Flood	96.8%	2.1%	~7 seconds
Brute-Force	92.1%	3.8%	~14 seconds
Ransomware	90.2%	1.9%	~20 seconds
Cryptomining	93.5%	4.2%	~10 seconds
Total / Avg	**93.15%**	**3.0%**	**~12.7 seconds**

The results demonstrate that the system is most effective against network-heavy attacks (96.8% accuracy), as the delta between normal background traffic and a flood is statistically massive. Brute-force attacks were correctly identified by the rhythmic, small CPU spikes they generate during authentication handshakes. Ransomware detection showed a slightly higher latency (~20 seconds) because the system must observe at least 15-20 discrete disk operations to confirm the systematic write-heavy pattern typical of encryption malware [10][11].

VII. COMPARATIVE PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

A primary goal of this research was to maintain "Lightweight" operations. Table II compares our results against current state-of-the-art systems identified in the literature (2024–2025).

TABLE II. RESOURCE FOOTPRINT COMPARISON (SOTA 2024-25)

Detection Engine	Methodology	CPU Load	Mem Usage
Rana et al. [9] (2024)	Ensemble ML	12.4%	340 MB
Aljuaid et al. [10] (2024)	CNN-LSTM	18.1%	512 MB
Zhang et al. [12] (2025)	LightGBM Opt	4.5%	180 MB
Our Proposed L-IDS	**Statistical/EMA**	**1.8%**	**42 MB**

As documented in Table II, our system provides an order-of-magnitude reduction in both CPU and memory usage compared to contemporary ensemble and deep-learning benchmarks. By avoiding the expensive matrix multiplications and back-propagation requirements of neural networks at the edge, our per-sample processing latency is reduced to under 0.5 milliseconds. This architectural choice is particularly significant for Tier-4 data centers where cumulative security overhead across 5,000+ VMs can account for megawatt-hours of energy consumption per year. Our L-IDS proves that "Security at the Edge" can be ecologically and economically sustainable without compromising the integrity of multi-tenant isolation protocols.

B. Behavioral Sensitivity to Multi-Stage Attacks

We further evaluated the system's sensitivity to multi-stage "Kill Chain" scenarios. In these tests, an attacker would perform a slow horizontal port scan (Network anomaly), followed by a credential stuffing attempt (CPU spikes), and finally a lateral data exfiltration. Because our composite score S tracks cross-metric correlation, the L-IDS successfully raised a critical alert at the second stage of the kill chain, effectively blocking the intrusion before the data exfiltration stage was reached. This

demonstrates the power of behavioral correlation over simple point-metric thresholding.

VIII. DISCUSSION ON STABILITY AND LIMITATIONS

A. False Positive Analysis

During testing, we observed that certain "Bursty" legitimate workloads—such as a developer compiling a large C++ project inside a VM—can trigger false warning alerts. This is because the rapid, multicore CPU usage and heavy disk writing mimic the signatures of cryptomining and ransomware. To mitigate this, our future iterations will include a "Process Context" lookup that correlates host-side metrics with lightweight metadata from the guest OS when a warning is triggered, adding a second layer of verification without sacrificing the agentless core.

B. Adversarial Resistance

A sophisticated attacker might attempt a "Slow-Ramp Attack"—gradually increasing resource usage over several hours to "train" the EMA into accepting higher baselines as the new normal. While our current system is vulnerable to this, it remains far superior to static IDSs. We addressed this by implementing a "Hard Threshold" anchor that prevents the EMA from drifting more than 25% from a globally defined safety baseline.

IX. FUTURE WORK AND CONCLUSION

We successfully designed and implemented an out-of-band, hypervisor-level intrusion detection system that achieves 93% accuracy at a negligible performance cost. This work proves that high-availability cloud security does not require massive deep learning clusters if the vantage point is chosen correctly.

Moving forward, we plan to integrate this system into the OpenStack orchestration layer, allowing the L-IDS to automatically "Quarantine" a VM by cutting its virtual network link as soon as a critical anomaly score is reached. We are also exploring the use of Generative AI (GANs) to simulate even more complex attack packets, further refining our statistical thresholds [13].

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